

CliftonStrengths Reflection

Utsav Acharya

Wright State University

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Dr. Mindy S. McNut

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Introduction

A strength can be understood as a natural ability that becomes more effective when it is developed through knowledge, practice, and experience. According to Northouse, strengths are patterns of thinking, feeling, and behaving that can be refined into productive leadership behaviors when individuals invest effort into them (Northouse, 2025). Instead of focusing only on weaknesses, strengths-based leadership encourages people to build on what they already do well. Developing strengths is important because it increases confidence, motivation, and overall performance. When individuals understand their strengths, they can contribute more effectively in teams and leadership roles. In my opinion, working on strengths allows people to grow faster because they are building on something that already exists naturally. This approach also creates more authentic leadership because people lead in ways that match who they are rather than trying to imitate others.

My Strengths

My top five CliftonStrengths themes are Achiever, Learner, Responsibility, Strategic, and Relator. The Achiever theme describes individuals who have a strong drive to accomplish tasks and maintain productivity, often feeling satisfaction from completing goals and staying busy (Gallup, 2017). Learner represents people who enjoy gaining knowledge and improving skills, with excitement coming from the process of learning rather than only the outcome. Responsibility refers to individuals who take ownership of commitments and feel personally accountable for what they promise to complete. Strategic involves the ability to see patterns, evaluate options, and create effective plans when facing challenges. Relator describes individuals

who value close relationships and prefer working with people they trust to achieve shared goals. Research also supports that strengths-based development improves engagement and leadership effectiveness because individuals perform better when using their natural talents (Ortiz et al., 2025).

I was mostly not surprised by my results because they reflect how I usually approach situations in daily life. Achiever and Learner felt especially accurate because I naturally push myself to complete tasks and improve skills. Responsibility also made sense since I feel uncomfortable when I fail to meet expectations or promises. Strategic surprised me slightly because I did not always recognize how much I plan ahead or think through multiple solutions, but after reading the description I realized I often do this when solving problems. Relator also fits my personality because I prefer meaningful connections instead of large groups or surface-level friendships. Overall, the results felt realistic and helped confirm how I see myself.

I use Achiever in school by setting goals for assignments and trying to complete work early so I can improve quality before deadlines. For example, when working on projects, I often create a schedule to stay productive. I use Learner by watching tutorials, reading additional materials, or practicing skills outside of class when I want to understand something more deeply. Responsibility appears when I participate in group projects because I make sure my part is finished on time and I support teammates if they need help. Strategic helps me when planning long-term goals, such as deciding what courses to take or thinking about career options after graduation. Relator is visible in my relationships because I focus on building trust with close friends and classmates, which makes teamwork easier and more effective. These strengths influence both my academic success and my interactions with others.

Conclusion

One important thing I learned from this reflection is that strengths are not just personality traits but tools that can be intentionally developed over time. Understanding my strengths helped me recognize why certain tasks feel easier and more motivating, while others require more effort. This awareness gives me more confidence because I know where I naturally perform well. My next step will be intentionally using my Strategic strength to improve long-term planning for my career. I plan to create clear goals and evaluate different options before making decisions because this will help me become more prepared for future leadership roles. Developing this strength further will allow me to grow academically and professionally while also becoming a more effective leader.

References

Gallup. (2017). CliftonStrengths for students. Gallup Press.

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Ortiz, S. S., Besiktepe, D., & Benhart, B. L. (2025). Building better teams: CliftonStrengths assessment in construction management education. *Proceedings of Associated Schools of Construction*, 6, 270–278.